



BEFORE

Success at [the Second Battle of Bull Run](#) left Confederate general Robert E. Lee facing an important decision: how to follow up his victory.

DRIVING FORWARD

The Union troops defeated by Lee had retreated into the defenses of Washington, D.C. Now Lee **chose to invade the North**. On every front, the Confederates were poised for action. In Arkansas, General Thomas Hindman was preparing to retake Missouri. In Mississippi, Earl van Dorn and Sterling Price were gathering forces for a possible offensive against Ulysses S. Grant's Army of the Tennessee. On September 3, 1862, just three days after Second Bull Run, Lee wrote to President Jefferson Davis: "The present seems to be the **most propitious time . . . for the Confederate Army to enter Maryland.**"

Advanced units of General Robert E. Lee's army began fording the Potomac River on September 4. He was acutely aware that the physical state of his force was poor: "It lacks much of the material of war," he wrote to President Davis, "is feeble in transportation, the animals being much reduced, and the men are poorly provided with clothes and in thousands of instances are destitute of shoes." Lee believed that the Union forces around Washington were also "in a very demoralized and chaotic condition" after Second Bull Run, and that the cautious General George McClellan now commanding them would stay in his defensive positions for at least four weeks. Lee's presence in Maryland might tip opinion in the North against continuing the war; at the very least, it would keep the Union armies on the defensive. But if Lee thought the Union Army was dispirited, he also had concerns about his own.